Chapter Number	Chapter Heading	Articles Covered
XV	On the European Union	88-1 to 88-7
XVI	On Amendments to the Constitution	89
XVII	(Repealed)	–

*Articles 78 to 86 were repealed.

2. Rigid Constitution Unlike the British Constitution, the French Constitution is rigid in nature. It contains a special procedure for its amendment. It can be amended by the Parliament by 60 per cent majority vote in both the houses. Alternatively, the President can call a national referendum on constitutional amendment. However, the republican form of government in France is not subject to amendment. Thus, there is no place for monarchy in France.

3. Unitary Constitution France is a unitary state. There is no division of powers between the central and local governments. All powers are vested in the single supreme Central Government located in Paris. The local governments are created and abolished by the Central Government for administrative convenience. In fact, France is more unitary than Britain.

4. Quasi-Presidential and Quasi-Parliamentary The French Constitution provides neither Presidential nor parliamentary government. Rather, it combines the elements of both. On one hand, it provides for a powerful President who is directly elected by the people for a five-year term, on the other, there is a nominated council of ministers headed by the Prime Minister which is responsible to the Parliament. However, the ministers shall not be the members of the Parliament.

Over a period of time, the provisions of the Constitution relating to the mode of election, tenure of office and number of terms of the President of France have been amended. These are mentioned in Table 95.2.

5. Bicameralism The French Parliament comprises the National Assembly (the lower house) and the Senate (upper house). The National Assembly has 577 members who are directly elected for a five-year term. The Senate has 348 members who are indirectly elected for a six-year term. The National Assembly is more dominant and powerful than the Senate.

6. Rationalised Parliament The Constitution of France established a rationalised Parliament, that is, a Parliament with restricted and limited powers. The powers of the French Parliament are restricted *vis-a-vis* the political executive. It can make laws only on those items which are defined in the Constitution. On all other matters, the government is empowered to legislate by executive decree. The Parliament can also delegate law-making power to the executive branch. These limitations on parliamentary authority were imposed to provide for a strong executive.

7. Constitutional Council France has a Constitutional Council. It consists of nine members who are appointed for a term of nine years. It functions as a judicial watchdog and ensures that the executive decrees and parliamentary laws conform to the provisions of the Constitution. However, it is only an advisory body and its opinion is not binding.